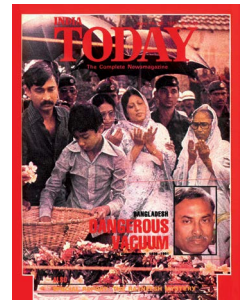
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

A country can choose its friends but not its neighbours. Sadly, troubled and troublesome neighbours surround India. A dramatic example is the recent ignominious end brought to Sheikh Hasina's 15-year-plus reign as prime minister by a student uprising in Bangladesh. The same pattern of civil unrest followed by regime change was witnessed in Sri Lanka in 2022. Pakistan has seen its army back a move to unceremoniously oust Imran Khan as premier and support a flawed election that resulted in unprecedented street protests, threatening the old military dominance itself. However, the export of terrorists across the LoC continues unabated. In Nepal on July 14, the pro-China communist K.P. Sharma Oli was sworn in again as premier, though in a coalition with the pro-India Nepali Congress. The Maldives, a tiny nation with an outsized influence on New Delhi's strategic calculations, also has a blatantly pro-China president now in Mohamed Muizzu—in fact, he won his 2023 election on an "India Out" plank. In Myanmar, the ruling junta is engulfed in a bloody civil war that has seen the regime losing control over half its territory. Then there is the giant shadow of China cast over the whole region. Besides its troubled 4,056 km border with India, it views all of South Asia with predatory interest and practises its Wolf Warrior Diplomacy wherever it finds an opportunity.

Calm should return soon to the streets of Bangladesh now that an interim government has been named under Nobel laureate Muhammad Yunus. Yet, there's a diplomatic lesson here for New Delhi. The anger against Hasina's autocratic regime was being extrapolated to everything associated with her—symbolised most tellingly by statues of Bangladesh's founding father and Hasina's father, Sheikh Mujibur Rahman. So the deluge of rage spilled over the embankments to include India, which has traditionally backed Hasina's Awami League. She represented a historic connection for New Delhi with the 1971 events that brought Bangladesh to its birth. She was secular, a guarantor of security to the Hindu minority. She also stamped out anti-India activities, including by Northeast militants. India used Hasina's friendship to settle the land border disputes and build vast infrastructure projects that improved bilateral connectivity and economic ties. But the bargain saw India turn a blind eye to her increasingly authoritarian governance, which stamped out all opposition with incarceration and disappearances. India's monochrome stance came in for sharp criticism and, with Hasina's ouster, we are seen as the 'enemy of the people' in Bangladesh. Geopolitically, it raises the danger of the new regime being less receptive to Indian concerns and more amenable to Chinese overtures. Hasina's arch-rival Khaleda Zia, now out of jail, was always seen to be anti-India during her reign. Instead of building bridges with her, India bet heavily on Hasina's seeming invincibility and is paying the price.

In diplomacy, putting all your eggs in one basket is folly. With flux-ridden polities, one must cultivate all sides. India is surrounded by countries in which China has the potential for considerable leverage. In Nepal, Prime Minister Oli's tilt will do no harm to Beijing's growing infrastructure interests there.



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In the Maldives, the pro-Chinese president Muizzu plans to allow the Chinese to develop a naval base in the archipelago. In Sri Lanka, the ousted Rajapaksa family seeks to retake power in a forthcoming presidential election with the 38-year-old son of former president Mahinda Rajapaksa, Namal. The Rajapaksas are known to play China against India, so there could be a fresh twist to that chapter of instability in Colombo. Only in Pakistan can India not be accused of having played favourites, perhaps because there are none. But every other factor applies. The uncertainty in Pakistan and Myanmar raises security concerns equally: witness the spate of terror attacks in Jammu and the refugee influx and cross-border militant bases roiling India's Northeast. And both are aligned with a very active China, which is easily bed-hopping across regimes.

Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa spoke to a wide range of foreign policy experts and brings their geostrategic ken to bear on this troubling canvas for our cover story this week. They offer sage counsel: wearing the vigilant security lens is vital, but economic partnership is what gives a soft depth to ties. India's engagement with Sri Lanka illustrates this best. After the fall of the Rajapaksas, to prevent a total economic collapse, India extended a lifeline of about $4 billion, more than the short-term IMF bailout of $3 billion. The Lankans are grateful for the timely and generous aid, which helped rebuild the ailing nation. That positive sentiment endures even if the regime changes. Observing South Asian responses to China is instructive. Even an inimical regime like Muizzu's in the Maldives now sees India's value and is dialling down its antipathy. In the past decade, China overtook India as Nepal's top foreign investor but, after the hype, Kathmandu, too, is arriving at a more nuanced appreciation of its India partnership.

Our neighbours realise that Chinese ingress is built around aggressive debt diplomacy and a big appetite for asset acquisition. India, the local Big Brother, is far more benign. Despite a $24 billion bilateral trade with China dwarfing its $14 billion transactions with India, Dhaka may also come to appreciate that regimes may be temporary, but interests are permanent. New Delhi must develop a neutral bilateralism to help this along and insulate its 'sphere of influence' from local flux. Take a leaf from the Gujral Doctrine: give more than you take from your smaller neighbour. Even in India's troubled relationship with China, after all the chest-thumping, it may finally be common economic interests that will offer a way. That's what gives everyone a stake in peace. Finally, despite all the criticism heaped on the functioning of India's constitutional democracy, we should be proud that in 77 years of Independence, there has been a peaceful transfer of power from one regime to another. This is a rarity in the whole of Asia. Kudos to us.

(Aroon Purie)